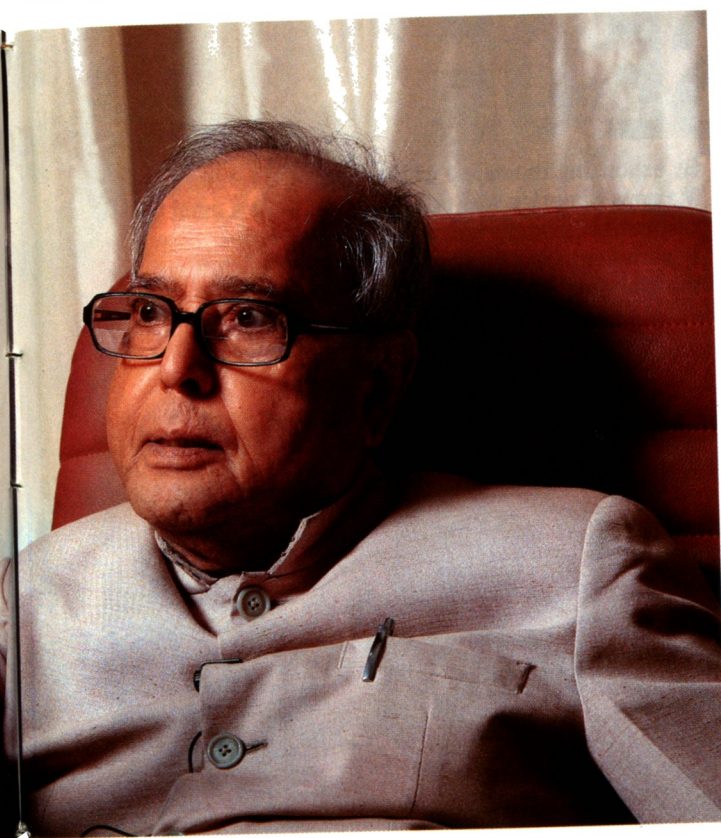




"We are not enhancing or reducing our weapons programme. We are strictly adhering to the doctrine of having a minimum credible deterrent."

strategic options are being capped.

A. They owe the nation an explanation as to why they said after 1998 that India does not need to test anymore. Why? What prompted them to declare unilateral moratorium? My point is if we had the right to test in 1998 then we still have it now. At that point of time by exercising our right we had to face some consequences. It may happen exactly the same way. There is not an alteration of the situation at all. Nothing has been conceded. Therefore this is absolutely baseless criticism.

Q. The Left wants a special session of Parliament and accuses the Government of lying after US Congressman Howard Berman leaked the letter about the nuke deal.

A. What is lying? If I knew something and I didn't tell the truth then I am lying. But in this case, how can I be privy to what transpired between the executive and the legislative wing of the US Government? We are only concerned with what we are party to, like the 123 Agreement and others. What is the basis of this accusation?

Q. What about the issue of fuel supply assurances for new reactors that are being raised?

A. You have to judge it with what is mentioned in the 123 Agreement. As I said, the waiver is just

the passport. The visa will be the bilateral agreement that we will sign with the individual NSG countries we do business with.

Q. You said India would wait till the US deal is complete before you start nuclear trade with other NSG countries?

A. No. What I said was different. I said the 123 Agreement is not complete till it is ratified by the US Congress so we have to wait till the whole process is finalised before we can conduct nuclear trade with the US. Theoretically nothing prevents us from signing up with other countries.

Q. So we can do business with other countries like France and Russia.

A. Of course we can approach other countries to start business and we would like to do it quickly.

Q. Will you be amending the domestic Atomic Energy Act to allow private companies into nuclear trade?

A. It is too early to say. The current thinking is the Government will do the trade through the Atomic Energy Commission. I can't comment on what will happen after the general elections and when a new government is in place.

Q. What about our weapons programme?

A. The nuclear doctrine has been enumerated by the previous Vajpayee government and we are strictly adhering to it. We are not enhancing or reducing our programme. We must have a minimum credible nuclear deterrent, so that nobody will attack us with nuke weapons because they know our retaliation would be unacceptable to them. We are not interested in stockpiling of nuclear weapons or a nuclear arms race.

Q. Were you disappointed that you couldn't build a consensus on the nuclear deal and prevent the Left from walking out of the UPA?

A. It was difficult, their differences were ideological. They told us you can have the deal with France and Russia but not with the US. What could we do? I can't change their ideological perceptions. And with Russia and France it was not possible without NSG clearance.

Q. Will Asif Zardari taking over as the President help foster better ties with Pakistan?

A. I would like to watch, action is much more important than words. After the new Government took over, I went to Pakistan. I had discussions with them and there was no dearth of words. After that, the ceasefire has been violated, infiltration has increased, the Kabul blasts occurred and the rhetoric has returned. We have sent them some concrete proposals on crossborder trade to start from October 1. If we get a positive response, we will be happy. Work is more important than words.

For full text of the interview, log on to

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